

IE, IE, ya...suku suku!

Hi,

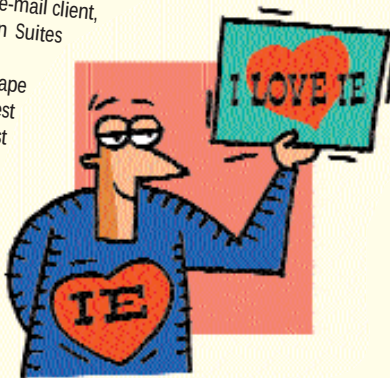
I have a complaint about the browser test ('Surf Wars') in your October issue. Firstly, the browsers were not properly categorised. Opera, which has its own engine, download manager, instant messenger (ICQ) as well as an e-mail client, should have been placed in the Internet Communication Suites category.

Secondly, you have over-hyped the performance of Netscape 6.1. All your benchmarks indicated Internet Explorer as the best performing browser. The only areas that I can see where it lost out were in terms of installation size and the lack of an HTML Editor, which is not too important. Also, there are programs like Hotbar that allow you to skin Internet Explorer.

I have used almost all the browsers you tested and am well acquainted with their performances. Internet Explorer 6, without a doubt, should be adjudged best browser.

GURU SABHARWAL

Via e-mail



digit

Dear Guru,

Let's start with your point about Opera. While as you say all of those features (e-mail client, instant messenger, etc) have been included in new versions of Opera, it just has a fraction of the functionality that is offered by similar components in other programs. In addition to just checking whether a feature is present, it is important to consider whether it is implemented well enough for you to consider shifting over to it. In that sense Opera does not challenge the likes of Internet Explorer and Netscape, at least not yet.

We believe Opera is a really neat piece of software that excels as a standalone browser. This is the reason that it ended up winning in the other category.

As you mentioned, Netscape 6.1 took nearly twice as long as IE to render Web pages. However, if you consider that most of us use dial-up connections where the availability of bandwidth is what eventually determines

performance, then it doesn't really make sense to give an extremely high weightage just to the performance in the rendering speed tests.

The skinning feature in IE, even using Hotbar, is limited to being a simple background for the toolbar, whereas Netscape 6.1 lets you modify the appearance of everything ranging from the icons, the mail client, the menus and even the progress-indicator bar. Thus the customisation can give the browser a completely new look and feel.

And let's not turn a blind eye to the security issues that IE and Outlook come with. Vulnerabilities in these have been repeatedly exploited by a variety of worms and viruses. Also, IE uses a crippled version of the JVM, and doesn't entirely comply to W3C specifications when it comes to HTML rendering.

So...we know that Netscape 6.1 is the best browser around, at least for now.

Goof Ups

■ Jadesh R. has rightly pointed out that the price of the Intel Pentium 4 1.8 GHz processor is Rs 26,668 as mentioned in the A-List and not Rs 11,868 as mentioned in Radar (Hardware).

■ In the browsers' comparison test (October issue of Digit), Arun Das has pointed out that on page 146, in the table, we have indicated the installation size of Opera 5.12 as 36 MB and in the write up below as 39 MB. The correct installation size is 36 MB.

Notice any goof-ups? Write to goof@jasubhai.com

Short Bytes

Diverse drivers

Dear Karan,

It would be nice if you could include the latest versions of popular hardware drivers on the Digit CDs once in a while. I am certain this will be welcomed and appreciated by many readers.

T. Chinnadurai

Via e-mail

Peek-a-boo

Hi Digit,

You guys have really improved on this magazine since the first issue of Digit. The CD contents have improved remarkably and the new look in October is phenomenal. It would be nice to receive information on the forthcoming issue of Digit via e-mail every month.

Anshul

Via e-mail

If you have suggestions on how to make Digit better, come participate in the reader survey at <http://www.thinkdigit.com/survey/betterdigit>

To Agent 001, with love

Hi,

The Undercover article in the August issue ('The Perfect Match') talked about Agent 001's experiences while trying to get a great price/performance deal on a motherboard and CPU combination. This inspired me to sell off my AMD 450 MHz processor and build a new Duron 850 MHz system.

However, when I got to Mumbai's hardware Mecca, Lamington Road, I got into a bit of a jam. The prescribed motherboard was out-of-stock, and the several (pretty expensive) alternatives had me pretty confused.

Which is when I had a brainwave!

"Hello, Digit? Can I speak to Agent 001 please?" They told me he was "undercover" but transferred me to someone in the Test Centre who discussed some options with the vendor and helped me select a model. Then he went ahead and helped me bring the price down and 10 minutes later I was dashing back home to assemble my new PC!

You guys will be glad to know that my PC is working great and as a Digit fan, I am delighted that you have such helpful guys on your team.

So, here's a special thanks to the Test Centre, and to Agent 001!

BILLI KASH

Via e-mail

digit

Dera Billi,

Agent 001 would have loved to have answered your question himself but was called away on another assignment. But he did ask us to say that it's great to hear that you got what you wanted for your PC. Anytime that you find yourself in a situation like this again and need advice on how to get a good deal, just flip to the Undercover article in the magazine for Agent 001's take. And if you still can't make head or tail of the situation, we're just an e-mail away.

Send your letters marked 'Readers Letters' to the Digit office:
D-222/2, MIDC, TTC Industrial Estate, Om Sagar Building, Nerul,
Navi Mumbai 400 706, Phone: 022-7629191/9200; Fax: 022-7629224
E-mail: readersletters@jasubhai.com